Israel: Anti-Netanyahu bloc faces fragile mandate

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Israel's opposition will likely win power with a fragile coalition

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The opposition bloc against Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, likely to be led by former Israel Defense Forces Chief of Staff Gadi Eisenkot, remains ahead in Eurasia Group’s polling average and is the basecase to form the next government, but it is still short of a 61-seat majority.
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An opposition government would likely reduce near-term escalation risks with Iran by operating more cautiously under US constraints, while cooperating with Lebanon on Hezbollah disarmament and preserving Israel’s ability to act against threats in southern Lebanon.
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Israel’s economy would likely mitigate headwinds under an opposition government that improves ties with Europe, reduces sanctions risk, and shelves a judicial overhaul, though far-right resurgence and social strains would persist.

The opposition is likely to win the October election. With less than two months until elections on 27 October, Eurasia Group’s polling average shows the anti-Netanyahu bloc, likely to be led by Eisenkot, polling in the mid-50s of Knesset seats. This opposition is just short of the 61-seat threshold for a majority. Netanyahu’s coalition is polling in the low 50s, well below a majority. The opposition remains the basecase to form the next government (60%), though Netanyahu retains a pathway to hold onto power (40%) (see: Likely opposition win would diminish threat of Israeli strikes on Iran , 2 July 2026).

The opposition's coalition math will likely force it to depend on the Arab party Ra'am. Parties in the anti-Netanyahu coalition on average poll at 53 to 55 seats. The opposition could seek to recruit the unaligned Reservists-New Economic Plan (NEP) party, if it passes the electoral threshold, but that still likely leaves it short of 61 seats. Under Israel's winner-take-all 3.25% threshold, parties that fall short of Knesset entry win zero seats, and their votes are redistributed among qualifying parties.

Ra’am, which joined the short-lived governing coalition in 2021, is the likely bridge, but its inclusion will cause frictions with other opposition parties and much of the electorate. Ra’am leader Mansour Abbas’s decision to give former senior law enforcement official Yoav Segalovitz the number two spot on his slate could smooth the party’s entry.

The anti-Netanyahu bloc could also attempt a minority government with Ra’am supplying support from outside the coalition. The Joint List—a political alliance of Arab-majority parties—polls at around eight seats and is not a candidate for inclusion in any coalition.

Netanyahu’s clearest path to survival is opposition coalition failure. The opposition’s difficult coalition math is key to our view that Netanyahu retains a shot at holding onto power in either a caretaker capacity until the next election (30%) or by assembling a new majority coalition (10%).

Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich’s Religious Zionist party—which polling showed was at risk of falling below the electoral threshold—has likely staved off this threat, for now, through a merger with Moshe Feiglin’s Zehut. A broader far-right merger also encompassing National Security Minister Itamar Ben-Gvir's Jewish Power party and former general Ofer Winter’s People of Israel party failed to materialize.

The gap between the two blocs could narrow as a result of the 8 September consolidation of the far-right and non-aligned parties, giving Netanyahu greater room to assemble a coalition. To form a new coalition, he would still likely need one opposition party to defect—a long shot.

Opposition victory would reduce Israel’s escalation risk and ease economic pressures. An opposition government would likely reduce near-term escalation risks, especially with Iran, by operating more cautiously under US constraints, while cooperating with Lebanon on Hezbollah disarmament and retaining freedom of action to confront challenges south of the Litani River.

It would also likely help mitigate economic headwinds by improving ties with Europe, reducing sanctions risk, and shelving Netanyahu’s planned judicial overhaul. Still, medium-term challenges would persist: Social polarization has deepened along religious, ethnic, and security fault lines; far-right parties have consolidated their mainstream presence; and structural economic pressures, including elevated defense spending, public debt, and a strained social contract, would remain regardless of who leads the next government.

Settlement sanctions create exposure risks but their economic significance depends on implementation. Twelve Western countries announced restrictions on trade with Israeli settlements in early September, circumventing EU-level coordination difficulties through a “coalition of the willing.” The domestic political and electoral impact is likely marginal, as the measures are more likely to reinforce existing preferences than change them.

Measures against violent settlers would be symbolic, while bans on settlement goods would have a modest impact given their small share of Israeli exports. The more consequential exposure runs through implementation. Restrictions on companies enabling settlement activity, as UK Foreign Secretary Ed Miliband signaled, could draw in a far wider range of Israeli firms. This uncertainty could also weigh on portfolio investment.

Governments more critical of Israeli settlement policy could adopt broader measures once the precedent is established, and bilateral diplomacy could shape their trajectory. A new opposition-led coalition could create grounds for partial easing by curbing settler violence or advancing peace negotiations with the Palestinians—but opposition leaders have been reluctant to commit to enforcement, and any crackdown risks a settler backlash that could destabilize a fragile coalition. The persistence of the broader settlement enterprise would limit any wholesale rollback of sanctions.

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